



SILK ROAD SHUTDOWN

016 / 01 OCT 2013 / BITCOIN / RARE

DREAD PIRATE ROBERTS.

An ordinary library table becomes the centre of a very different kind of transaction. A man in a red T-shirt turns from his computer as an agent reaches across the table. Another figure closes in behind him. Between them sits the object that matters most: a laptop with its lid still open. In this illustration, the tension comes from a few seconds of interrupted routine.

On 1 October 2013, federal agents arrested Ross Ulbricht at San Francisco's Glen Park library. Under the name Dread Pirate Roberts, he had operated Silk Road, a hidden online marketplace that ran from 2011 to 2013. Tor concealed connections to the site, while bitcoin served as its means of payment. The market became notorious for illegal drug sales, bringing Bitcoin into a story far beyond the early experiments in digital cash.

Contemporary trial reporting described an undercover agent keeping Ulbricht engaged in an online conversation as the arrest team moved. Securing his open, unlocked laptop was crucial: investigators wanted access before he could close it or lock them out. The scene turns on that vulnerability, where an online identity meets the person and computer behind it.

The marketplace was shut down, but Bitcoin itself continued. That distinction is central to the card: a service using the currency could be seized without stopping the wider network. Here, the shelves, readers and afternoon light make the interruption feel immediate. The dramatic window reflections belong to the illustration; the historical focus is the arrest and the laptop taken at the table.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE OPEN LAPTOP

The central object recalls the investigators' effort to seize Ulbricht's computer while it was unlocked. Its screen faces him; the picture invents no readable account balance or seizure total.

02 SCIENCE FICTION

The shelf sign nods to the library section identified in reports of the arrest. The interior itself is a stylized setting, not an architectural reconstruction.

03 THE PRINCESS BRIDE

The book points to the origin of the Dread Pirate Roberts name. This copy on the table is an illustrated clue, not a documented possession at the arrest.

04 GLEN PARK

The small borrowing slip names the San Francisco library branch. It places the scene without turning the backdrop into a map; the slip is a fictional prop.

05 LIGHTS AT STREET LEVEL

Low red-and-blue reflections hint at activity outside, with the cars kept out of sight. They are a cinematic addition, not a verified detail of the operation.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

The [FBI's laptop record](#) confirms the alias, arrest date and computer seizure. [WIRED's trial report](#) describes the unlocked-laptop operation; [TIME's account](#) supplies library and literary context. The [DOJ's later seizure announcement](#) is dated 25 October, so its bitcoin total is not shown as an arrest-day screen detail. Ross is a stylized likeness; the agents' faces, poses, layout and incidental props are fictionalized.